

Water Crisis–

Shahapur, Thane

Key Statistics of the Water Shortage Situation in Shahapur taluka

42 WATER-SCARCE VILLAGES / HAMLETS

(↑ from **26** last year)

Currently facing **acute water shortage**.

12,683 PEOPLE AFFECTED

by acute shortage

15 TANKERS DEPLOYED

(↑ from **8** last year)

To supply areas facing scarcity.

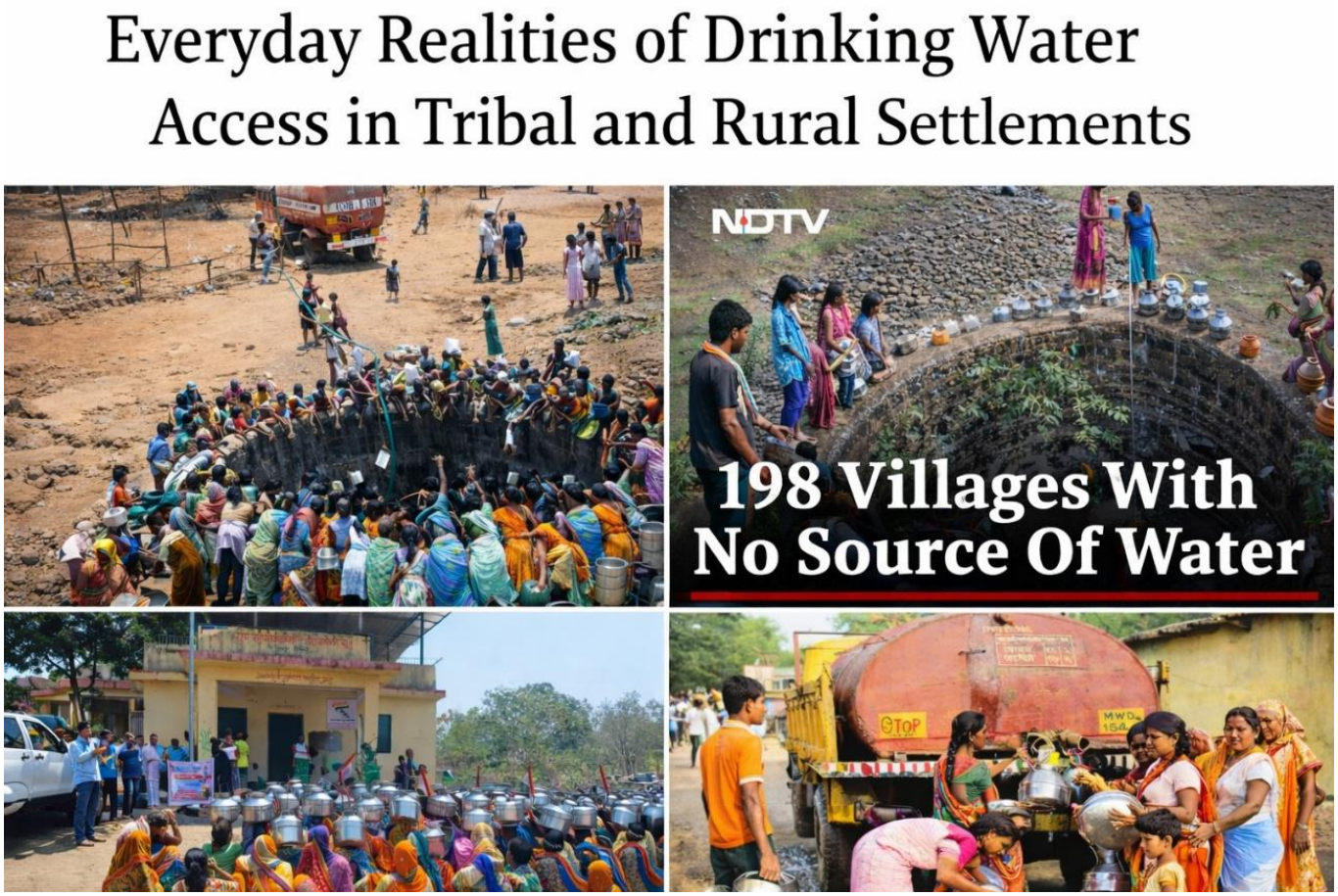
High **rainfall** but villages struggle due to limited storage and poor distribution infrastructure.

Source: ZP Thane Water Supply Dept.; CGWB Groundwater Reports (2013–2022); Lokmat & Free Press Journal (2023–24

BUILDING SHAHAPUR – THE PLACE FORGOTTEN

Shahapur taluka, located in Thane district of Maharashtra, has a population of over **314,000 people**, with nearly **77% residing in rural areas** (Census of India, 2011; Zilla Parishad Thane, 2023–24). The region has a high concentration of **Scheduled Tribe communities (approximately 36%)**, including Katkari, Warli, and Thakur groups, and children aged 0–6 years constitute about **13% of the total population** (Census of India, 2011; ICDS Shahapur, 2023–24).

Despite being situated in a **high-rainfall zone** and forming part of a catchment area that supplies water to major urban centers, many villages in Shahapur continue to face persistent challenges related to **safe drinking water access, child malnutrition, limited healthcare infrastructure, and livelihood insecurity** (ZP Thane Health Department, 2023–24; NFHS-5). Field-level surveys and NGO monitoring reports indicate that a significant number of hamlets remain dependent on water tankers, lack permanent health facilities, and show high levels of undernutrition among tribal children (Population First – AMCHI, 2024; TISS-IRHDP Field Reports, 2023).





Reason for selecting shahapur

Shahapur was selected as the focus area due to the **sharp mismatch between natural resource availability and development outcomes**. Although the taluka receives above-average annual rainfall, systemic gaps in water storage, distribution, and infrastructure have resulted in chronic water scarcity across several villages (CGWB Groundwater Reports, 2013–2022; Jal Jeevan Mission status, ZP Thane).

The area is also characterized by a **high proportion of tribal hamlets**, low female literacy, and recurring **seasonal distress migration**, particularly among Katkari and Thakur communities

(Census of India, 2011; TISS-IRHDP, 2023). Children and women are disproportionately affected due to limited access to healthcare, nutrition services, and stable livelihoods (ICDS Shahapur, 2023–24; Population First, 2024).

From an NGO and CSR perspective, Shahapur represents a **high-need, high-impact geography**, where focused and cluster-based interventions in water security, child health, and livelihood strengthening can generate measurable and sustainable outcomes. The presence of active NGOs and CSR initiatives further supports convergence-based programming and long-term engagement (ZP Thane NGO Mapping, 2024; Shahapur Field Reports).

Root Cause: Structural Water Scarcity in Shahapur

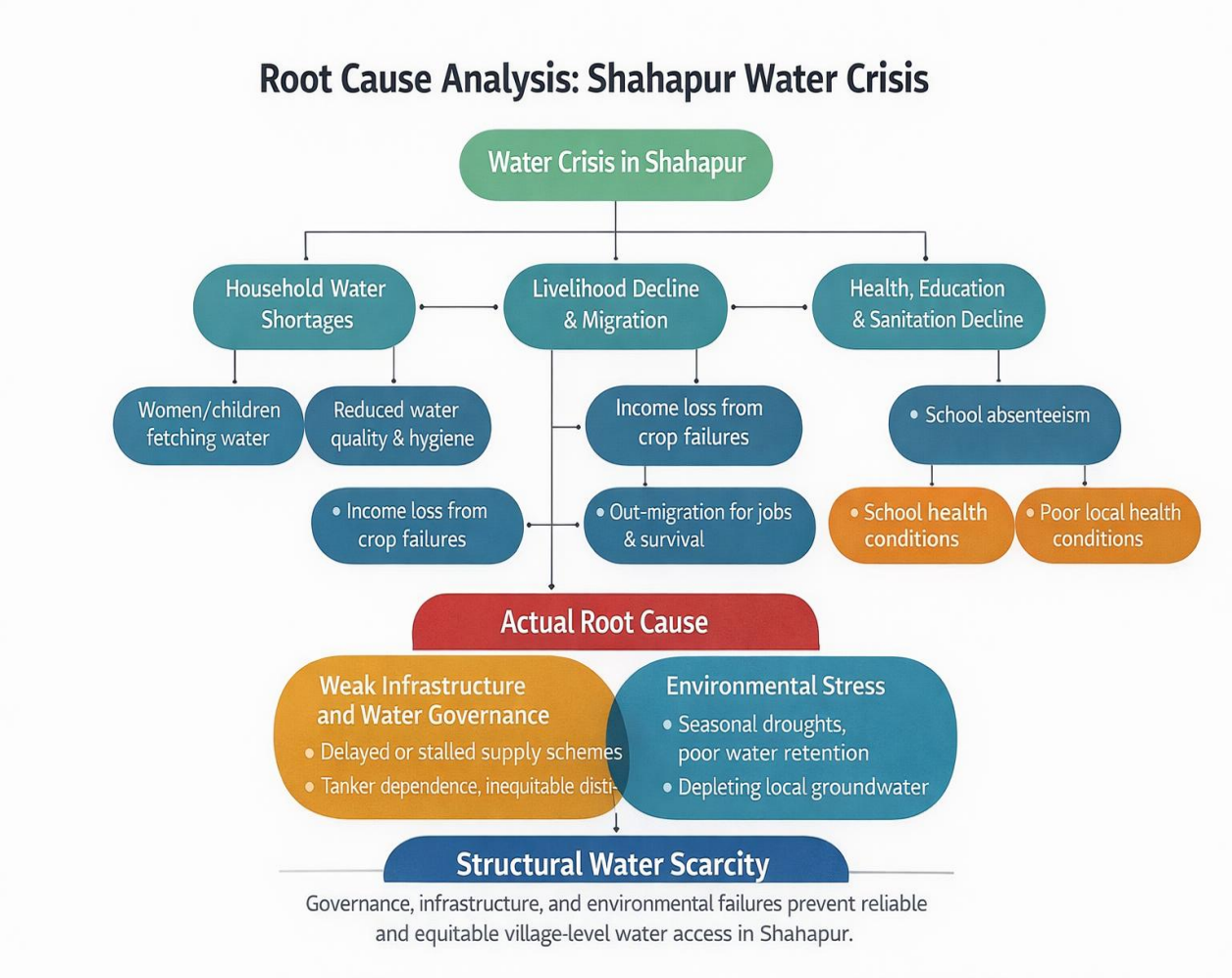
Shahapur's development challenges are rooted in **chronic water scarcity**, which is not simply a result of low rainfall but a product of structural and institutional failures. Despite the presence of nearby water sources, many villages face persistent shortages because local water infrastructure and governance systems have failed to ensure reliable access. Delayed or poorly implemented water supply schemes, heavy dependence on tanker services,

inadequate storage and groundwater recharge structures, and poor connectivity to remote and tribal hamlets have collectively produced a condition of insecure water access at the village level.

This structurally driven water scarcity has wide-ranging socio-economic consequences. Agriculture and livestock rearing, which form the backbone of local livelihoods, suffer due to irregular irrigation and declining groundwater levels, leading to crop failures and income instability. As livelihood options shrink, households increasingly resort to seasonal or distress migration in search of employment. Within households, women and children bear a disproportionate burden, spending long hours fetching water, which reduces time available for education and productive activities and contributes to school absenteeism.

Water scarcity also undermines health and nutrition outcomes. Limited and poor-quality water weakens sanitation and hygiene practices, increasing vulnerability to illness and malnutrition, especially among children. Environmental stressors such as seasonal droughts and groundwater depletion aggravate the situation, but the fundamental root cause remains

the failure to translate available water resources into sustainable, equitable, and secure local access.



Ongoing Development Work and Institutional Presence in Shahapur

Shahapur taluka has attracted the attention of several **non-governmental organizations (NGOs), trusts, and corporate social responsibility (CSR) initiatives**, primarily due to its high tribal population, persistent water scarcity, and poor child health indicators. Current development work in the region focuses on **health and nutrition, water security, education, and limited livelihood support**, though coverage remains uneven across villages.

Health and Child Nutrition Initiatives

Multiple organizations are addressing **child malnutrition and primary healthcare gaps**, particularly in tribal hamlets:

- **Population First** is implementing the *AMCHI (Action for Malnutrition-free Children Initiative)* in Shahapur, monitoring thousands of tribal children for early detection of undernutrition and linking families with ICDS and health services (Population First, AMCHI Programme Reports; NFHS-5).
- **TISS – Integrated Rural Health and Development Project (IRHDP/Pragati)** has a long-standing presence in Shahapur, focusing on **tribal health, education, and livelihood systems**, including mobile health outreach (TISS Field Reports; Ministry of Tribal Affairs references).
- **Tata Memorial Foundation (TMF)**, through its nutrition and community health initiatives, has supported the identification and management of **Severe Acute Malnutrition (SAM)** cases in tribal regions of Maharashtra, including Shahapur (TMF Programme Briefs; ICDS convergence reports).

These efforts complement government schemes such as **ICDS**, **NHM**, and **POSHAN Abhiyaan**, but the absence of permanent health facilities in most villages continues to limit impact.

Water Security and Natural Resource Management

Despite high rainfall, Shahapur faces recurring drinking water shortages due to inadequate storage and distribution systems.

- **Suadha NGO** works on **tribal water access, skill development, and community-based natural resource management** in the Shahapur–Aghai belt (Suadha Annual Reports).
- **Natural Solutions** and **Vasundhara Sanjivani Mandal** are engaged in **watershed development, groundwater recharge, and water conservation** projects in Shahapur and adjoining tribal blocks (CGWB-linked watershed documentation).
- CSR initiatives from companies such as **Mahindra Group** and **Mazagon Dock Limited** have supported **water pipelines, rural infrastructure, and agriculture-related works** in selected villages (CSR disclosures; MCA CSR Portal).

These initiatives align with government programs like the **Jal Jeevan Mission**, though many schemes remain delayed or incomplete.

Education and Tribal Welfare Programs

Educational interventions in Shahapur are largely supported by **local trusts and education-focused NGOs**, with emphasis on tribal children:

- **Archana Educational Trust**, **Bharode Educational Trust**, and **Durvankur Shikshan Sanstha** support **Adivasi schooling, hostels, and Zilla Parishad schools** (NGOs India Portal; District Education Office listings).
- **Parivartan NGO** and **Umang Foundation** conduct **learning support programs, teacher assistance, and school infrastructure support** (NGO directories; CSR–NGO partnerships).

However, **seasonal migration, poor school infrastructure, and limited secondary education access** continue to affect retention and learning outcomes.

Livelihoods, Migration, and Community Welfare

Livelihood interventions remain limited relative to need, even as **seasonal distress migration** remains high among Katkari and Thakur communities.

- **Pravas Foundation**, **Janiv Pratishtan**, and **Sai Mauli Samajik Sevabhavi Sanstha** provide community welfare and social support services at the taluka level.
- Migration trends documented by **TISS**, **Ministry of Tribal Affairs**, and national media highlight Shahapur as part of a broader **tribal distress migration corridor** in north Maharashtra.

Target cluster

We are choosing **Cluster A1 – Fugale–Aghai belt** (Fugale, Aghanwadi, Varaswadi, Kalamgaon, Dhasai, Veholi/Veholi Budruk, Birwadi and Aghai) as our primary focus area because it represents the most severe and multi-dimensional water crisis in Shahapur's tribal hills. Wells here are drying up or contaminated, forcing women and children to walk long distances for unsafe water, while tanker supply remains irregular and insufficient. At the same time, these villages show high vulnerability in terms of malnutrition, low literacy, migration and weak health and education services, so improvements in water security can unlock wider gains in nutrition, health, schooling and livelihoods for a concentrated group of high-need tribal communities.

Cluster	Villages in this cluster (6–10)	Severity of water crisis	Affected population (best available)	Demographic details of this cluster
A1 – Fugale–Aghai belt	Fugale, Aghanwadi, Varaswadi, Kalamgaon, Dhasai, Veholi (Veholi Budruk), Birwadi, Aghai	Very severe: wells dried or almost dry; some wells contaminated with sewage and waste; people trek 12–15 km daily for water; villages flagged among the six worst-affected in Shahapur's Jal Jeevan Mission zone.	Around 1,600 residents reported in Fugale; about 1,200 people in Fugale + Aghanwadi + Varaswadi together receiving emergency tankers. For the wider six-village belt (Fugale, Kalamgaon, Dhasai, Veholi, Birwadi, Aghai), no precise combined figure is in public reports, but it is a few thousand people.	Tribal-dominated hill and forest belt on Shahapur–Kasara side. Shahapur overall: 35.7% ST; many Warli, Katkari, Thakur, Konkana households; 13.1% children 0–6; female literacy only 58.41%. Articles explicitly describe these as adivasi/tribal villages with scattered padas up the hills, matching that profile.

Typical livelihoods of in Cluster A-1

In the Fugale–Aghai belt, most families depend on **rainfed paddy and small-scale farming**, which makes their income highly vulnerable to erratic rainfall and water shortages. Men frequently migrate seasonally to work in brick-kilns and construction sites in nearby urban centres such as Kalyan, Ulhasnagar, Badlapur and other towns, often for several months a year. Women and older children are left managing both household work and livelihood activities, including forest wage labour and casual daily-wage work whenever it is available. Because local water sources are unreliable or far away, they spend long hours each day walking to fetch water, carrying heavy pots from wells, streams or tanker points. This daily burden reduces time available for education, childcare, rest and income-earning work, trapping the community in a cycle of low income, poor health and high drudgery.

NGOs operating in region

The Thane Zilla Parishad Water Department is supplying **alternate-day tanker water** to Fugale, Aghanwadi, and Varaswadi, reflecting acute drinking water scarcity. These **six gram-panchayat villages** are covered under the **Jal Jeevan Mission** and **Bhavli Pani Yojana**, though multiple works remain stalled due to contractor apathy and pending wildlife approvals. The belt is also a **priority focus under the Shivjal Surajya Abhiyan**, which aims to make Shahapur and Murbad tanker-free through bunds, check-dams, desilting, and groundwater recharge. Complementing government efforts, NGOs such as **Suadha**, **Vasundhara Sanjivani Mandal**, **Natural Solutions**, and **ShivAA** are active in tribal water security and watershed work. CSR partners including **Mazagon Dock**, **Karve Institute**, **Mahindra Logistics**, along with ECGC–Suadha and Nomura–Bala Vikasa models, have supported check-dams, pipelines, and community-managed water systems in similar Shahapur-type tribal villages.

Name	Type	Main water-related focus	Likely / known reach in this belt
Thane Zilla Parishad – Rural Water Supply Dept	Govt	Emergency drinking-water supply by **tankers**; oversees Jal Jeevan Mission and quality-affected sources.	Currently sending tankers on alternate days to **Fugale, Aghanwadi and Varaswadi**; responsible for schemes in Kalamgaon, Dhasai, Veholi, Birwadi, Aghai
Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) & Bhavli Pani Yojana	Govt scheme	Household tap-water schemes, village pipelines, source strengthening.	All six gram-panchayat villages (Fugale, Kalamgaon, Dhasai, Veholi, Birwadi, Aghai) fall under these programmes, but many works are **stalled** due to contractors and wildlife clearance
Shivjal Surajya Abhiyan	Govt (district programme)	Making Shahapur and Murbad **tanker-free** by constructing **bunds, check-dams, desilting, recharge structures**, with convergence of district, tribal, MGNREGS and CSR funds.	Fugale–Aghai belt is a priority cluster because it is highlighted as severely tanker-dependent; works are targeted at tribal and hill villages like these.
Suadha NGO	NGO	**Water projects and check-dams** along with tribal skills; active in **Khoste, Aghai and foothills**	Very relevant for Aghai, Dhasai, Kalamgaon, Veholi and nearby padas; their check-dam and rainwater harvesting model in Shahapur can be replicated towards Fugale and surrounding hamlets.
Vasundhara Sanjivani Mandal	NGO	**Water conservation** (check-dams, recharge, watershed) in Shahapur and Murbad.	Works in Shahapur taluka; suitable partner for soil-and-water works in Veholi, Birwadi, Kalamgaon and Aghai side villages.
Natural Solutions	CSR-supported org	**Watershed and water-conservation** projects in Shahapur/Jawhar region.	Not village-specific in public data, but clearly focused on Shahapur; technically fit for catchment and recharge work on the Fugale–Aghai hills.

Name	Type	Main water-related focus	Likely / known reach in this belt
ShivAA NGO	NGO	**Tribal health and water** on Shahapur border.Shahpur.pdf	Reaches tribal hamlets at the edge of Shahapur; relevant for water-plus-health work in scattered padas around this belt.Shahpur.pdf
Mazagon Dock (via Karve Institute)	CSR	**Roads, water and agriculture** in Shahapur hamlets; finances infrastructure like small pipelines, culverts and village roads.	Works in Shahapur hamlets generally; good CSR partner to extend **pipelines, storage tanks and access roads** in Fugale–Aghai villages
Mahindra Logistics	CSR	**Water pipelines** in **Tembha (Shahapur)**	Demonstrates a pipeline-focused CSR model in Shahapur; can be extended to this belt for gravity-fed or pumped village supply
ECGC–Suadha model	CSR+NGO	Funded **check-dam and rainwater harvesting** projects in Shahapur (Awala–Mahuli–Katekui) through Suadha.	Model can be replicated in hilly catchments above Fugale, Aghanwadi, Varaswadi and others to create perennial sources
Nomura / Bala Vikasa model	CSR+NGO	**Community water systems / purification plants** in rural India, including projects in Maharashtra districts facing drinking-water quality issues.	Relevant where Fugale's wells are **contaminated with sewage**, to combine new sources with community purification and storage.

CSR organisation	Maharashtra locations / scope	What work they have done (Maharashtra)	Stated future plan / direction
HDFC Bank – Parivartan	Jalgaon, Palghar, Jalna and other districts	In Jalgaon, created 31 groundwater-recharge structures to tackle drought and improve water for farmers.hdfc In Palghar, co-funded solar mini piped-water systems for villages like Panshetpada and Jambhulichapada, giving 75+ households in each village household taps.thecsruniverse+1 Impact assessments from Jalna district show improved water availability and agricultural outcomes under their rural-development programmes.hdfcbank	Aims to bring 2 lakh acres under irrigation nationally by March 2025 through watershed and rainwater-harvesting projects (which include Maharashtra districts).bfsi.economictimes.indiatimes Also continuing the Palghar "50 water-secure villages" initiative with partners.cwas
Worldline India – Jal Sanjeevani	Rural Maharashtra (multiple districts)	Rejuvenated 26 water bodies in rural Maharashtra, increasing storage by approximately 29.5 crore litres and improving groundwater and irrigation for nearby farmers.thecsrjournal	Article describes Jal Sanjeevani as an ongoing initiative with emphasis on scaling to more water bodies in Maharashtra; it does not specify an exact future target beyond the initial 26 rejuvenated sites.thecsrjournal
Atlas Copco India	Pune and Beed districts	Installed school/community water systems (Aqua Towers) and supported the SPJR watershed project in Dharur, Beed, improving water availability and soil moisture in a drought-hit area.atlascopco	CSR communication highlights community water and watershed projects as ongoing priorities, including in Maharashtra; no numeric target is quoted in the article used.atlascopco
Godrej & Boyce CSR	Takavali village, Khalapur	Implemented a village water-supply project in Takavali, building storage	Company notes that improving access to clean water and WASH around its operations is a continuing CSR focus;

CSR organisation	Maharashtra locations / scope	What work they have done (Maharashtra)	Stated future plan / direction
	taluka, Raigad district	tanks and improving distribution so that villagers get more reliable access to clean water.thecsrjournal	specific numerical targets for Maharashtra are not provided in the article.thecsrjournal
Mahindra Group (incl. Mahindra Logistics)	Shahapur (Tembha), and other locations linked to Mahindra operations	Your Shahapur file documents water pipeline work in Tembha (Shahapur) funded by Mahindra Logistics CSR.Shahpur.pdf Group sustainability reports discuss broader water-positive goals and resource-efficiency initiatives, including micro-irrigation via Mahindra EPC.mahindra	Sustainability strategy commits to remaining water-positive and scaling efficient irrigation and water-management solutions; village-level future plans (like for Shahapur) are not detailed in the sources available.mahindraShahpur.pdf
Jamnalal Bajaj / Bajaj Water projects	Several drought-prone talukas in Maharashtra	Through campaigns like the Satyamev Jayate Water Cup, supported villages to create farm ponds, contour trenches, check dams, desilting of tanks and other water-conservation works, significantly enhancing water storage and resilience.ecoideaz	Intends to continue supporting village-led water-conservation competitions and projects in rural Maharashtra; no single numeric forward target is stated in the article.ecoideaz
ITC Watershed projects	Agrarian districts in Maharashtra	Implemented watershed development and soil-and-water conservation to support rainfed agriculture, increasing water storage and farm productivity in ITC's project villages.ecoideaz+1	ITC's sustainability approach emphasises ongoing expansion of watershed treatment and maintaining water-positive operations, including in Maharashtra; district-specific targets are not listed in the source consulted.softhunters